



**Taking a stand:** Vinesh Phogat had earlier returned her Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna and Arjuna Award in protest of the issues plaguing Indian wrestling. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

concerns, wants to transition smoothly into the 53kg category well before the Olympic trials. "I am cutting weight after a long gap, and there is no need to do it [dramatically]. The key is to save energy for the main competitions."

Vinesh, who got injured midway through a bout on her Olympic debut in 2016 and had a forgettable outing in the 2020 edition, is confident that she will be able to raise her game in the next five months.

"Yes, hopefully. I think I will play more freely in the next competition. The doubts are over. I will see how the body reacts after this competition."

Vinesh appeared to have a tentative training plan for the lead-up to the Olympics, but she

chose not to reveal whether she would enlist the services of a foreign coach.

"I will go abroad [for training]. My coach is coming. Let's see what kind of planning is done. The support staff is with me. There are so many people working behind the scenes."

Vinesh was excited to see several experienced wrestlers getting back into competition mode ahead of the Olympics.

"It is an Olympic year, and many senior athletes were injured. They are coming back on track now. Ravi (Dahiya) also competed and did well recently. Anshu (Malik) and I have won here. We want other wrestlers to follow the seniors and walk with us shoulder to shoulder. The bigger the team in the Olympics, the better it is."

Meanwhile, Vinesh has not given up her fight for athlete welfare. "We try to combine life on the mat and beyond it because, as senior athletes, our responsibility increases. I was continuously doing rehab after

my surgery. If we needed to meet someone, then Bajrang (Punia) and Sakshi (Malik) used to take that responsibility.

"I had stepped back a bit, even though we were together at every step. We are trying to continue our fight against injustice.

"They (the suspended WFI, headed by Brij Bhushan's acolyte Sanjay Singh) have been trying to create problems. Recently, they conducted another national championship in Pune, but the certificates issued for that event don't have any value. It's depressing for the athletes, and the government should take note of this."

Even though it is difficult for an Olympic-bound athlete to divide her attention, Vinesh feels the situation in the last year has taught her to balance her fights on and off the mat to achieve her target as well as a greater common goal.

The next five months should provide Vinesh with more clarity about her future.